

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Office and Administrative Assistant English

Conversation lab



8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Office assistants, administrative assistants, reception administrators, and team support staff.

All organizations, appointments, documents, prices, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This is not legal, financial, immigration, security, or records-retention advice. Follow the employer's actual purchasing, access, privacy, travel, and approval arrangements. Sample policies and delegated responsibilities apply only to the stated exercise.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

- 01 A daylight-saving assumption needs a date check
- 02 A message for an absent colleague
- 03 An absent attendee is not automatically an action owner
- 04 A correction after the document has been printed
- 05 The supplier offers a substitute color
- 06 An early visitor needs somewhere to wait
- 07 A reservation request without a confirmation number
- 08 Friday coverage with one unanswered supplier query

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.
2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.
3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.
4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.
5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

All organizations, appointments, documents, prices, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This is not legal, financial, immigration, security, or records-retention advice. Follow the employer's actual purchasing, access, privacy, travel, and approval arrangements. Sample policies and delegated responsibilities apply only to the stated exercise.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

A daylight-saving assumption needs a date check

An assistant and colleague review a cross-office invitation using a supplied date-specific conversion.

Roles: Assistant / Colleague

Assistant: The draft uses last month's time difference. Our verified conversion for this meeting date is different.

Colleague: I copied the old invitation. What local times should appear for the new date?

Assistant: The calendar shows nine here and three there, not the four shown in the draft.

Colleague: Then the other office may have reserved the wrong hour. Please check before confirming the meeting.

Assistant: I'll contact their administrator with the date and both proposed local times. Our nine remains a hold.

Colleague: Could you ask whether their room is available at three too, rather than check only the person's calendar?

Assistant: I've asked. The participant can attend at three, but their room is occupied until three-thirty.

Colleague: We can meet by video without that room. Does the participant have another suitable place available?

Assistant: They confirm a smaller room at three. I'll update the invitation with the corrected local times.

Colleague: Please state that the earlier four o'clock reference was an error, so nobody relies on it.

Assistant: Done. Both participants have accepted the corrected invitation, and the old time is identified in the correction.

Colleague: Thanks. I'll use this meeting's date-specific times rather than carry the old difference into future bookings.

Notice the professional language

'For this meeting date' limits a time conversion to the date verified.

'Remains a hold' keeps scheduling progress distinct from final acceptance.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

A message for an absent colleague

An assistant helps a caller reach the right backup contact.

Roles: Assistant / Caller

Assistant: Alex is away today. Would you like to leave a message or speak with the covering coordinator?

Caller: I need to change tomorrow's delivery window. Leaving it until Alex returns would be too late.

Assistant: The covering coordinator handles delivery changes. Could I confirm the reference before connecting your call?

Caller: It's D27, and the driver now expects to arrive at two instead of the agreed morning slot.

Assistant: I'll pass on the requested change, not describe two as accepted before the coordinator checks it.

Caller: Good. We can keep the original arrangement if the afternoon isn't possible, but need an answer today.

Assistant: That fallback is useful. May I tell the coordinator both the proposed time and the original alternative?

Caller: Yes. Please also say the delivery size hasn't changed; it's only the proposed arrival time.

Assistant: I've briefed them. They can take your call now and discuss whether the new window is possible.

Caller: Will I have to repeat my business number, or can you transfer the call directly to their extension?

Assistant: I can transfer you directly. If we disconnect, use the published direct line and quote D27.

Caller: Thank you. Please put me through; I can confirm the final window with the person arranging access.

Notice the professional language

direct line - A telephone number that reaches a particular person or team without going through the main reception number.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

An absent attendee is not automatically an action owner

An assistant checks whether a proposed task was accepted.

Roles: Assistant / Chair

Assistant: The draft minutes assign the visitor guide to Noor, but Noor wasn't at today's meeting.

Chair: Someone suggested Noor would be suitable. We didn't actually ask whether they could take it on.

Assistant: Then I'll record that as a proposed owner rather than an accepted assignment in the minutes.

Chair: Please ask Noor now; we need a first outline by Friday to discuss on Monday.

Assistant: I've spoken to Noor. They can review an outline Friday, but can't prepare it from scratch this week.

Chair: That changes the task. I can prepare the first outline Thursday and ask Noor to review it.

Assistant: Shall I record you as the drafting owner and Noor as reviewer, with those separate dates?

Chair: Yes. Please confirm Noor accepts the review before treating the revised arrangement as agreed.

Assistant: Noor has accepted Friday's review. They ask for the Thursday draft by four so they can plan their time.

Chair: I can send it by four. Monday's meeting can discuss the reviewed outline, not a finished published guide.

Assistant: I'll read back the sequence: your draft Thursday, Noor's review Friday, and discussion on Monday.

Chair: That's correct. The minutes now reflect what each person actually accepted rather than the first suggestion.

Notice the professional language

'Proposed owner' distinguishes a suggestion from accepted responsibility.

'Drafting owner' and 'reviewer' separate two different tasks on the same document.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

A correction after the document has been printed

An assistant coordinates an update to already printed meeting packs.

Roles: Assistant / Colleague

Assistant: Version four corrects the room, but you printed version three. How many packs are ready?

Colleague: Twelve. The meeting content is unchanged, but the front page sends people to room 210 instead of 201.

Assistant: The owner confirmed room 201. The printed packs need correcting too, not just the shared file.

Colleague: Could I replace just the front page rather than reprint the eleven unchanged pages in every pack?

Assistant: The owner has approved replacing that page. Please keep the revision label visible so the corrected packs are identifiable.

Colleague: I'll replace the fronts and check each pack. Are any already with attendees outside this room?

Assistant: Two were collected earlier by visitors. I'll contact their host and explain the corrected room number directly.

Colleague: Please ask for acknowledgment, since a new file in the folder won't change their printed copies.

Assistant: The host has confirmed both visitors know room 201 and will receive the corrected front page on arrival.

Colleague: I've finished the ten remaining packs here. All now show room 201 and the version-four label.

Assistant: The folder is current, these ten packs are corrected, and the host is handling the other two.

Colleague: I'll put a corrected pack by the entrance for the chair when they arrive.

Notice the professional language

'As well as the link' identifies a correction needed in another medium.

'Already with attendees' checks who may still rely on a superseded printed copy.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

The supplier offers a substitute color

An assistant coordinates a choice without changing a colleague's request silently.

Roles: Assistant / Supplier

Assistant: The requisition specified black desk organizers, and P63 carries that description. Your message offers gray instead.

Supplier: Black is on backorder. We can supply six gray organizers tomorrow if you accept the substitution today.

Assistant: The requesting team chose black to match existing storage. I need their decision before changing the order.

Supplier: Understood. The quoted unit price would stay the same, but the color would differ from your purchase order.

Assistant: Please hold the proposal while I check. Does waiting for black have a confirmed delivery date yet?

Supplier: No confirmed date. We expect an update Friday, but that isn't a promise that black stock arrives then.

Assistant: I've reached the requester. They can accept gray for all six if the stated price remains unchanged.

Supplier: The price remains as quoted. Please have your purchasing contact confirm the revised item description through your normal process.

Assistant: I'll ask purchasing to confirm the accepted color change; I haven't changed the order myself.

Supplier: That's fine. We'll keep the substitution pending until the purchasing confirmation reaches us, then confirm delivery arrangements.

Assistant: The team knows gray is accepted internally, but we're waiting for revised supplier confirmation.

Supplier: I'll acknowledge the purchasing confirmation when received, then send the actual delivery arrangements.

Notice the professional language

purchase order - A document issued by an organization specifying an order for goods or services.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

An early visitor needs somewhere to wait

An assistant checks arrangements for a visitor who arrives well before their appointment.

Roles: Assistant / Visitor

Assistant: Your appointment is at two. It's twelve-thirty now; did the host ask you to arrive early?

Visitor: No, my train was earlier than expected. Could I work in your meeting room until the host is available?

Assistant: That room is booked until one-forty-five. I can ask about a waiting space, but can't offer it now.

Visitor: I don't need the meeting room specifically. Somewhere to sit with my own laptop would be enough.

Assistant: There is a visitor seating area here in reception. The host confirms you may wait there until collected.

Visitor: That works. Can I leave my bag with you while I get a drink from the cafe?

Assistant: We don't provide unattended bag storage here. You can keep it with you or use another arrangement yourself.

Visitor: I'll keep it with me. Could you tell the host I've arrived without asking them to leave their current meeting?

Assistant: I've sent your arrival message. The two o'clock appointment remains unchanged.

Visitor: Thank you. I'm not asking for an earlier meeting, just avoiding another trip back from the station.

Assistant: The host will meet you here at two. Please wait in this reception area.

Visitor: I'll sit here with my bag and laptop until two. Thanks for checking.

Notice the professional language

'Not asking for an earlier meeting' separates arrival from a requested schedule change.

'Can't offer it now' ties a limit to a concrete room booking.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

A reservation request without a confirmation number

An assistant checks whether a hotel room is actually reserved.

Roles: Assistant / Traveler

Assistant: The hotel email says request received, but contains no confirmed reservation or booking reference.

Traveler: I thought that meant my room was booked. I need to know before arranging the journey.

Assistant: I'll contact the travel desk. Your itinerary should show the hotel request as pending until they confirm it.

Traveler: Please ask about the Tuesday arrival and two-night stay; the dates changed in an earlier message.

Assistant: They've confirmed the requested dates were correct, but the first hotel hasn't accepted the reservation.

Traveler: Is there another quoted option, or do we need to wait without a room for that trip?

Assistant: A second hotel has availability at the approved rate. The travel desk needs your preference before requesting it.

Traveler: The second location works. Please proceed through the existing approval arrangement and ask for the confirmation.

Assistant: The desk has now supplied booking reference H74 for Tuesday arrival and two nights at the second hotel.

Traveler: Can you remove the first hotel's name from the confirmed section of my itinerary so I don't go there?

Assistant: The itinerary now shows the second hotel and H74; the first request is closed without confirmation.

Traveler: I've checked it. I'll use that address and reference, and keep the confirmation with the itinerary.

Notice the professional language

booking reference - An identifier used to locate a specific travel or accommodation reservation.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 12 SPEAKING TURNS

Friday coverage with one unanswered supplier query

An assistant hands open work to the colleague providing afternoon coverage.

Roles: Assistant / Covering colleague

Assistant: Your two-to-five coverage includes one open supplier query under purchase order P77.

Covering colleague: What is confirmed, and what response are we waiting for before I contact the supplier this afternoon?

Assistant: Six chairs arrived, but one has a different code. The supplier is checking whether it was a substitution.

Covering colleague: Has anyone agreed to keep the different chair, or should I avoid describing it as accepted?

Assistant: Nobody has accepted it. The requesting team wants the ordered model, and the supplier promised an update at four.

Covering colleague: I'll follow up at four if no update arrives. Where can I find the item codes and delivery note?

Assistant: They're linked in the shift handover folder under P77. The photograph shows the labels, without any personal information.

Covering colleague: I can open both. If they offer a replacement date, who needs to confirm whether it suits us?

Assistant: Facilities must confirm the date against their receiving schedule; please ask their coordinator.

Covering colleague: I'll do that. My coverage includes the four o'clock query and passing any proposed date to facilities.

Assistant: Please record the supplier's actual response, even if the mismatch remains unresolved at four.

Covering colleague: Accepted. I'll report the status before five and keep the different model separate from any agreed replacement.

Notice the professional language

purchase order - A document issued by an organization specifying an order for goods or services.

delivery note - A document listing the goods a supplier states are included in a delivery.

Rehearse this dialogue with an AI partner

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Scheduling across calendars and time zones

SHARED CASE

A colleague asks for a 3:00 meeting with another office. For this fictional date, 3:00 in the colleague's office equals noon at the other office. The request does not identify whose time is intended. Both calendars are open at that equivalent time; confirm the intended time before sending invitations.

Role A | Responding professional

Confirm whose clock a proposed meeting time refers to. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Colleague: mean three in your own office; can explain the supplied noon equivalent when asked.

Useful expressions

Do you mean ___ in ___ time?

On that date, it will be ___ for ___.

I've placed a hold; ___ is still unconfirmed.

Cover this until after your first attempt

When you say three o'clock, do you mean three in your office's time zone? On this date, that would be noon for the other office. Both calendars are open then, but I haven't sent an invitation. Please confirm the intended local time so I can label the meeting accurately.

Second round

One participant calls the time lunchtime. Check their local time rather than treating the phrase as a new booking request.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Taking useful calls and passing accurate messages

SHARED CASE

Caller Lena Park needs the facilities team about delivery D18, not the finance team about an invoice. Facilities extension is 214. Lena requests a callback before 4:00, but availability is unknown. Ask for the delivery reference and preferred contact route, then relay the requested deadline without promising it.

Role A | Responding professional

Request purpose, reference, and contact information without promising a callback time. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Caller: Lena Park, reference D18, want facilities and a reply before four; can give a work callback number orally.

Useful expressions

Is this about ___ or ___?

Let me read that reference back: ___.

You've requested a callback by ___; I'll pass that on.

Cover this until after your first attempt

Could I confirm that your call concerns delivery D18 for facilities, rather than an invoice query for finance? I'll route the message to extension 214. Please confirm your preferred callback details. I'll include your request for a response before four, but I haven't confirmed the team's availability.

Second round

The caller says they already spoke to accounts. Confirm whether the current question is still about physical delivery.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Preparing meetings and confirming action points

SHARED CASE

A meeting has ten minutes left and two agenda items: printer replacement and visitor signage. The chair prioritizes the printer decision. Sam can obtain two quotes by Thursday; nobody has approved a purchase. Ask the group to confirm that action and defer signage to the next meeting.

Role A | Responding professional

Help participants confirm a task, owner, and deadline. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Chair: prioritize the printer; confirm Sam can obtain two quotes by Thursday; signage can wait unless someone raises a concrete urgency.

Useful expressions

Who will take ___, and by when?

The agreed action is ___; no decision on ___ yet.

Can we defer ___ until ___?

Cover this until after your first attempt

We have ten minutes left, and the chair has prioritized the printer item. Sam, can you confirm you'll obtain two quotes by Thursday? I'll record that as the action, not as purchase approval. Can we move visitor signage to the next agenda and confirm whether anyone needs that discussed sooner?

Second round

An attendee says the minutes should list a printer purchase. Clarify the actual decision before ending.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Checking document versions and access

SHARED CASE

An assistant sent version 2 of a visitor guide, but version 3 was approved this morning. The older version has the wrong reception floor. The current guide is in the shared folder; one recipient lacks viewing access. Correct the message and request access from the document owner without widening permissions independently.

Role A | Responding professional

Repair a version error without assuming a link works for everyone. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Recipient: have version two and a denied-access message on the new link; need the correct reception floor.

Useful expressions

I sent version ____; the current version is ____.

The corrected detail is ____.

Can you confirm you can view ____?

Cover this until after your first attempt

I sent version two, which gives the wrong reception floor. I'm sorry for the confusion. Version three was approved this morning and is the current guide in the shared folder. I'll send its link and ask the document owner to resolve your viewing access before you rely on the guide.

Second round

The recipient asks you to make the whole folder public. Request the necessary limited access from its owner instead.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Querying office supplies and delivery differences

SHARED CASE

Purchase order P44 is for twelve archive boxes. The delivery note lists twelve, but the checked shipment contains ten. No second package or backorder is documented. Ask the supplier to confirm the outstanding two and whether another shipment is planned; do not approve payment or claim theft.

Role A | Responding professional

Give order, stated quantity, received quantity, and the response needed. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Supplier: order P44 shows twelve; can investigate the missing two and provide an update at three, but have no confirmed explanation yet.

Useful expressions

The order lists ____; we received ____.

Could you confirm whether ____?

Please give us the next update by ____ if agreed.

Cover this until after your first attempt

Purchase order P44 lists twelve archive boxes, and the delivery note also lists twelve. We received ten in the checked shipment, leaving a difference of two. Could you confirm whether another package is due or whether this is a short delivery, and give us the next update time?

Second round

The delivery note is signed. Keep the reported physical count separate from assumptions about what the signature proves.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

Welcoming visitors and checking arrangements

SHARED CASE

Visitor Taylor arrives for a 10:00 meeting with Jordan. The office has two Jordans: Jordan Chen in facilities and Jordan Patel in sales. Reference V12 names Jordan Chen. Check the reference, contact the host, and explain the reception wait; the visitor is not cleared to enter other areas alone.

Role A | Responding professional

Use the appointment reference to identify the right receiving colleague. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Visitor: Taylor, booking V12, meeting Jordan at ten; do not know Jordan's surname.

Useful expressions

Could I check your appointment reference?

That lists ___ in ___.

Please wait here while I contact ___.

Cover this until after your first attempt

We have two colleagues named Jordan, so could I check your appointment reference? V12 lists Jordan Chen in facilities. I'll contact that host now. Please wait here in reception while we confirm the receiving arrangements; I'll update you as soon as Jordan responds.

Second round

The visitor sees someone wearing a badge and asks to follow them upstairs. Keep the host-confirmation arrangement clear.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Clarifying travel options and booking status

SHARED CASE

Two fictional rail quotes cover the same trip. A costs \$70 and is nonrefundable; B costs \$90 and permits a refund before departure with a \$10 deduction. The traveler's meeting is not confirmed. Purchasing approval is still required. Compare the supplied conditions without recommending financial or legal action.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain price and cancellation flexibility using the supplied terms. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Traveler: meeting might move; need a clear comparison and approval before any booking.

Useful expressions

Both cover ___, but their conditions differ.

Under these terms, cancellation before ___ means ___.

Neither is booked; we still need ___.

Cover this until after your first attempt

Both quotes cover the same trip. A costs seventy dollars and is nonrefundable; B costs ninety and allows a refund before departure with ten dollars deducted. Your meeting is still unconfirmed, so that flexibility may matter. Neither option is booked, and purchasing approval is still needed before we proceed.

Second round

The traveler says refundable means no conditions. Read back the specific deduction and before-departure limit.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Prioritizing work and handing over coverage

SHARED CASE

At 10:00 an assistant has a visitor list due at 10:30 and a room pack due at 11:00. Each needs thirty minutes. A manager requests a new twenty-minute spreadsheet check by 10:20. No colleague is free. Ask the manager to choose priorities or adjust a deadline; do not promise all three.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate task order using actual durations and agreed deadlines. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

Manager: visitor list must stay at 10:30; can move the spreadsheet check to 11:20 while keeping the pack at eleven.

Useful expressions

I have ___ due at ___, requiring ___.

Adding ___ means ___ will be delayed.

Which deadline can we revise with ___?

Cover this until after your first attempt

I have the visitor list due at ten-thirty and the room pack at eleven, each needing thirty minutes. The new check adds twenty minutes before ten-twenty, so I can't complete all three by those times. Which should take priority, and which deadline can we revise with the person waiting for it?

Second round

The manager calls the extra task urgent without changing its duration. Ask which existing commitment should change.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Say one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Lesson conversations and speaking practice

The following sections match 05 and 06 on the industry webpage and in the learner workbook. Each lesson has three ten-turn conversations and two bounded speaking scenarios. These are original fictional teaching scripts, not transcripts of real people.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Whose three o'clock?

An assistant checks a meeting request before sending invitations.

01 • Assistant: You asked for three o'clock. Which office's time zone did you mean for this meeting?

02 • Colleague: Three here, please. I hadn't realized my message left that detail open for you.

03 • Assistant: For this date, that's noon in their office. Both calendars show an opening then.

04 • Colleague: Good. Could you reserve half an hour and include both local times in the invitation?

05 • Assistant: Yes. Is this a confirmed meeting, or should I place a tentative hold while you ask Dana?

06 • Colleague: A tentative hold. Dana still needs to agree, even though the calendar looks free.

07 • Assistant: I'll mark it tentative and wait for your confirmation before describing it as accepted.

08 • Colleague: Please allow fifteen minutes afterward as buffer time before my next call as well.

09 • Assistant: The calendar permits that. I've held thirty minutes plus the separate fifteen-minute buffer.

10 • Colleague: Thanks. I'll ask Dana today and tell you whether to confirm or release the hold.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Back-to-back meetings leave no travel time

An assistant flags a scheduling conflict.

01 • Assistant: Your client meeting ends at two, and the next appointment starts across town at two.

02 • Manager: I didn't notice the locations. That would leave no travel time between those appointments.

03 • Assistant: The second host offered two-thirty as an alternative. Would you like me to check that slot?

04 • Manager: Yes, but ask about the meeting length before moving anything already in the calendar.

05 • Assistant: It's a thirty-minute discussion, and their two-thirty opening is still available this afternoon.

06 • Manager: Then move the second appointment to two-thirty and keep the first one unchanged.

07 • Assistant: I'll send the revised invitation and identify the location so nobody expects a video call.

08 • Manager: Please ask the host to acknowledge the change rather than assume they saw the calendar update.

09 • Assistant: They've accepted two-thirty at their office. Your first meeting still ends here at two.

10 • Manager: Good. That leaves the agreed travel buffer, and I can prepare for the correct location.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

One occurrence, not the whole series

An assistant clarifies a recurring-meeting change.

01 • Assistant: You asked to move next Tuesday's team call. Should the later weekly meetings stay unchanged?

02 • Colleague: Yes. Only next Tuesday needs moving because the visitor presentation overlaps with it.

03 • Assistant: The recurring series is at ten. Do you want that one occurrence at eleven instead?

04 • Colleague: Eleven works, and the usual thirty-minute length can stay the same for that date.

05 • Assistant: I'll change the individual occurrence, not every future invitation in the series.

06 • Colleague: Please make that clear in the update, because people may assume our weekly schedule has changed.

07 • Assistant: The message will name the specific Tuesday date and confirm later weeks remain at ten.

08 • Colleague: Can you also leave the original video link in place if the meeting system allows it?

09 • Assistant: The updated invitation retains that link. I've checked the revised date and time before sending.

10 • Colleague: I've received it. Only next Tuesday now shows eleven; the following week still shows ten.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Scheduling across calendars and time zones

A colleague asks for a 3:00 meeting with another office. For this fictional date, 3:00 in the colleague's office equals noon at the other office. The request does not identify whose time is intended. Both calendars are open at that equivalent time; confirm the intended time before sending invitations.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Colleague: mean three in your own office; can explain the supplied noon equivalent when asked.

Second round: One participant calls the time lunchtime. Check their local time rather than treating the phrase as a new booking request.

Scenario 2 | An all-day hold hides an available hour

A calendar shows an all-day tentative planning hold. The owner can release 1:00-2:00 for a supplier call but wants the rest kept. The supplier has not accepted.

Role A: Assistant: clarify the partial release and keep supplier acceptance pending.

Role B: Calendar owner: authorize only the one-hour release.

Possible opening: Can you clear that planning hold so I can speak to the supplier?

Success checks

- Name the released hour.
- Keep the rest of the hold intact.
- Distinguish available time from supplier acceptance.

Add a complication: A colleague assumes the entire day is now free.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Delivery, not invoice payment

An assistant routes a supplier's call.

01 • Assistant: Is your question about the invoice or the physical delivery, so I can reach the right team?

02 • Caller: The delivery. I'm Lena Park, and our reference is D18. We need unloading arrangements.

03 • Assistant: Facilities handles that at extension 214. Would you prefer a transfer or a callback request?

04 • Caller: A callback, please. I need an answer before four if someone is available then.

05 • Assistant: I'll include that requested time. I haven't confirmed the team's availability for a return call.

06 • Caller: They have our office number from yesterday. Could you ask them to use that number again?

07 • Assistant: I'll check the stored business contact rather than copy a number from a different supplier.

08 • Caller: Please read the reference back as well; people sometimes hear B instead of D.

09 • Assistant: D18, with D as in Delta, for facilities about unloading arrangements before four if possible.

10 • Caller: That's correct. Please route it to facilities, not the accounts colleague I spoke to yesterday.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A similar surname needs spelling

An assistant checks the intended recipient of a call.

01 • Assistant: Did you ask for Morgan Lee or Morgan Leigh? Both work in this building.

02 • Caller: Morgan Leigh, ending G-H. We discussed next week's training room booking yesterday afternoon.

03 • Assistant: Thank you. That Morgan is in learning support, on extension 306, rather than sales.

04 • Caller: Yes, learning support is right. Could you put me through to that extension now?

05 • Assistant: I can try. Would you like to leave a message if the extension isn't answered?

06 • Caller: Yes. Please say the revised attendance count is eighteen, not the sixteen I gave yesterday.

07 • Assistant: I'll pass on the changed count if needed. Is there a reference Morgan will recognize?

08 • Caller: Training T52. You don't need the attendees' individual names for this particular message.

09 • Assistant: Understood. Morgan Leigh, learning support, T52, revised count eighteen. I'll connect you now.

10 • Caller: Thank you for checking the spelling; the wrong Morgan wouldn't know anything about the room.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A direct line is not a personal number

An assistant responds to an external caller.

01 • Assistant: I can offer the team's published direct line or take a message for the colleague.

02 • Caller: I was hoping for their personal mobile number so I could reach them this evening.

03 • Assistant: I can't share a private number. The published direct line is the available business contact.

04 • Caller: That's fine. Does calling the direct line guarantee they will answer rather than the team?

05 • Assistant: No, it reaches their team contact point; I can't promise who will be available.

06 • Caller: Then please take a message. I want to confirm the room booking reference A17.

07 • Assistant: Certainly. I'll include A17 and your request for confirmation, without adding any private details.

08 • Caller: Can you note that email is easier for me than another phone call today?

09 • Assistant: Yes, I'll use the business email address already recorded for this booking and note that preference.

10 • Caller: Thanks. A reply through that address will be enough; I don't need the personal number.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Taking useful calls and passing accurate messages

Caller Lena Park needs the facilities team about delivery D18, not the finance team about an invoice. Facilities extension is 214. Lena requests a callback before 4:00, but availability is unknown. Ask for the delivery reference and preferred contact route, then relay the requested deadline without promising it.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Caller: Lena Park, reference D18, want facilities and a reply before four; can give a work callback number orally.

Second round: The caller says they already spoke to accounts. Confirm whether the current question is still about physical delivery.

Scenario 2 | A callback number was heard incorrectly

A caller gives a fictional number ending 0614, but the assistant repeats 0641. The caller needs a room-booking response before Friday; no callback time is agreed.

Role A: Assistant: invite and acknowledge the correction.

Role B: Caller: correct the final four digits and confirm the Friday need.

Possible opening: The last four digits are zero-six-one-four, not zero-six-four-one.

Success checks

- Read back the corrected digits.
- State the room-booking purpose.
- Label Friday as requested rather than confirmed.

Add a complication: The caller interprets repeating Friday as a guaranteed callback deadline.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Quotes are an action, not an order

An assistant helps close a short office meeting.

01 • Assistant: We have ten minutes left and two agenda items. Which should we finish today?

02 • Chair: The printer decision needs attention first. Visitor signage can go on the next agenda.

03 • Assistant: Sam offered to get two quotes by Thursday. Shall I confirm that as the action item?

04 • Chair: Yes. Sam has accepted it, but we haven't approved buying a printer from either supplier.

05 • Assistant: I'll record Sam as the owner and Thursday as the deadline for those two quotes.

06 • Chair: Please don't call it a purchase decision in the minutes; we still need the comparison.

07 • Assistant: Understood. Does the signage item need an interim action before the next meeting?

08 • Chair: No. The current signs remain in place, and the review can wait until next Tuesday.

09 • Assistant: Then the open purchase decision stays open, and signage is scheduled for Tuesday's agenda.

10 • Chair: That's agreed. Please read those two points back to the attendees before we finish.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An action needs a person, not a department name

An assistant checks a meeting note with a colleague.

01 • Assistant: My note says operations will check the room equipment. Who accepted that action during the meeting?

02 • Colleague: I did. Please put my name, Mira, rather than leave it assigned to the whole department.

03 • Assistant: What did you agree to check, and was there a deadline for reporting back?

04 • Colleague: The screen connection and remote microphone, by Wednesday at noon, before Thursday's training session.

05 • Assistant: I'll record both items and that deadline. Was fixing any fault also assigned to you?

06 • Colleague: No. I'll report what works and raise any fault with support; I haven't promised repairs myself.

07 • Assistant: Thanks. That gives the minutes a clear action without extending your responsibility beyond the discussion.

08 • Colleague: Could you read the wording back? I want to make sure the deadline concerns my report.

09 • Assistant: Mira checks the screen connection and microphone and reports the results by Wednesday noon.

10 • Colleague: That matches. If there's a fault, the support request will be a separate follow-up.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A missing agenda attachment

An assistant helps an attendee find the meeting information.

01 • Assistant: You received the calendar invitation, but said the agenda wasn't attached. Is the meeting time visible?

02 • Attendee: Yes, Tuesday at ten is clear. I just don't know which topics need preparation.

03 • Assistant: The agenda is in the shared meeting folder. I should have included the link.

04 • Attendee: Could you send that link rather than another attachment that might become an older copy?

05 • Assistant: Certainly. The current agenda has three items, and your presentation is the second one.

06 • Attendee: How much time is allocated to it? I need to keep the example within the meeting limit.

07 • Assistant: Ten minutes for the presentation and five for questions, according to the current agenda.

08 • Attendee: That gives me fifteen in total. I'll plan the presentation for ten, not use all fifteen.

09 • Assistant: I've sent the folder link. Please check that you can open it before the meeting.

10 • Attendee: It opens now. I'll prepare ten minutes of presentation for the second agenda item.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Preparing meetings and confirming action points

A meeting has ten minutes left and two agenda items: printer replacement and visitor signage. The chair prioritizes the printer decision. Sam can obtain two quotes by Thursday; nobody has approved a purchase. Ask the group to confirm that action and defer signage to the next meeting.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Chair: prioritize the printer; confirm Sam can obtain two quotes by Thursday; signage can wait unless someone raises a concrete urgency.

Second round: An attendee says the minutes should list a printer purchase. Clarify the actual decision before ending.

Scenario 2 | A meeting ends without a deadline

The team agrees that Leon will compare two room-booking systems, but no date is stated. Leon can provide a comparison Friday; the chair needs it Thursday and can accept an initial summary then.

Role A: Assistant: invite a feasible deadline and distinguish summary from full comparison.

Role B: Leon: offer Thursday's summary and Friday's full comparison.

Possible opening: Before we finish, when should Leon bring back the comparison?

Success checks

- Name Leon as owner.
- Confirm two distinct deliverables and dates.
- Read back the agreed action aloud.

Add a complication: An attendee assumes Thursday means the complete comparison.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Correct guide, blocked link

An assistant corrects an outdated visitor-guide attachment.

01 • Assistant: I sent version two earlier. Version three was approved this morning and corrects the reception floor.

02 • Recipient: That explains the difference from the invitation. Which file should I use for tomorrow's visit?

03 • Assistant: Version three in the shared folder. I'm sorry the earlier attachment gave the wrong floor.

04 • Recipient: I've opened your new link, but I get an access-denied message rather than the guide.

05 • Assistant: I'll ask the document owner to grant the viewing access you need for that file.

06 • Recipient: Please don't make the whole folder public just for me; I only need the visitor guide.

07 • Assistant: Agreed. I've requested access to that document. The owner has now confirmed the permission change.

08 • Recipient: Let me try again. It opens, and version three says reception is on the second floor.

09 • Assistant: That's the current information. Please use that link rather than the older downloaded attachment.

10 • Recipient: I've marked the downloaded copy as old. I'll use this link tomorrow.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

View access is enough for the task

An assistant clarifies a colleague's file-access request.

01 • Assistant: You asked for access to the supplier schedule. Do you need to read it or update entries?

02 • Colleague: Only read it. I'm checking the arrival times before I prepare the room list.

03 • Assistant: Then viewing access is enough. I'll ask the document owner for it.

04 • Colleague: I don't need edit rights, and I don't want to change anything accidentally while checking.

05 • Assistant: Your access permission is view-only. The owner has sent the current file; can you open it?

06 • Colleague: It opens now. I can see the Tuesday delivery but can't type in the cells.

07 • Assistant: That's expected for viewing access. If you find an error, send it to the schedule owner.

08 • Colleague: The room number on one line may be wrong. I'll ask the owner to confirm it.

09 • Assistant: Please quote the delivery reference so they can find the exact entry you're questioning.

10 • Colleague: I'll quote D43 and Tuesday's date when I ask the owner about that room.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

An attachment name conceals an older revision

An assistant checks two similarly named files with a colleague.

01 • Assistant: Both attachments are called final agenda, but their revision dates differ. Which one did the chair approve?

02 • Colleague: The one revised at eleven today. The earlier file still has the old speaker order.

03 • Assistant: I'll use the timestamp and the approved shared-folder copy, not the filename final by itself.

04 • Colleague: Could you check that the opening speaker is Rosa before you send the agenda to attendees?

05 • Assistant: The current approved copy lists Rosa first and Daniel second. That matches the chair's message.

06 • Colleague: Good. Please send the link so people don't keep editing separate copies from their inboxes.

07 • Assistant: I'll do that. What should I tell someone who already downloaded the earlier attachment?

08 • Colleague: Ask them to use the current link; don't assume their downloaded copy updates automatically afterward.

09 • Assistant: The message now names the eleven o'clock revision and explains that the speaker order changed.

10 • Colleague: That's enough. Everyone can check the same current agenda before tomorrow's meeting starts.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Checking document versions and access

An assistant sent version 2 of a visitor guide, but version 3 was approved this morning. The older version has the wrong reception floor. The current guide is in the shared folder; one recipient lacks viewing access. Correct the message and request access from the document owner without widening permissions independently.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Recipient: have version two and a denied-access message on the new link; need the correct reception floor.

Second round: The recipient asks you to make the whole folder public. Request the necessary limited access from its owner instead.

Scenario 2 | A link opens the template, not the completed document

A colleague sends a blank visitor-list template instead of the completed list for Thursday. The completed version is in a restricted shared folder. The requester already has viewing permission there.

Role A: Assistant: identify the wrong file type and send the correct existing link.

Role B: Requester: need Thursday's completed list, not a new template.

Possible opening: This opens a blank form; where are Thursday's attendees?

Success checks

- Identify the completed Thursday list.
- Keep the template separate.
- Confirm the requester can view the corrected link without changing permissions.

Add a complication: The sender assumes the requester wants to edit the template.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Twelve on the note, ten in the shipment

An assistant calls a supplier about archive boxes.

01 • Assistant: I'm calling about purchase order P44. We ordered twelve archive boxes, but the shipment contains ten.

02 • Supplier: Our delivery note lists twelve. Have you checked whether two were packed in a separate package?

03 • Assistant: We've checked the received shipment and have no second package or backorder notice recorded.

04 • Supplier: Thank you. I'll ask dispatch to check the packing record for those two boxes.

05 • Assistant: Could you confirm whether another package is due and tell us when you'll update us?

06 • Supplier: I can give you an update at three today. I can't confirm another shipment yet.

07 • Assistant: Three is helpful. We need the missing boxes for Friday, but haven't promised their arrival internally.

08 • Supplier: I'll include that need in the query without changing the delivery date before dispatch responds.

09 • Assistant: Please use P44 in your reply so we can keep it with the delivery note.

10 • Supplier: I'll quote P44 when I call you at three with dispatch's update.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An internal request has not reached the supplier

An assistant checks a colleague's supply request.

01 • Assistant: Your requisition for notebooks is in the internal approval queue. Have you received any purchasing confirmation?

02 • Colleague: No. I assumed submitting the form meant the supplier had already been asked to deliver.

03 • Assistant: Not yet. A purchase order hasn't been issued, so there isn't a confirmed supplier delivery date.

04 • Colleague: We need them Monday. Could you ask the approver to review the request today?

05 • Assistant: Yes. I'll add the Monday requirement and ask whether they can review it today.

06 • Colleague: Please tell the team we're still waiting for approval, not expecting a confirmed Monday delivery.

07 • Assistant: I will. I'll report the request status and any confirmed next step after the reviewer responds.

08 • Colleague: Could we check the supply cupboard in the meantime for enough notebooks for the first session?

09 • Assistant: There are six available. Would those cover the six attendees at Monday's opening session?

10 • Colleague: Yes. Six cover Monday's group. Please keep the purchase request active for later sessions.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A backorder is not a new order

An assistant discusses an undelivered part of an existing purchase.

01 • Assistant: Your message says the remaining four folders are on backorder. Are they still part of P58?

02 • Supplier: Yes. Eight of the twelve were delivered; four remain outstanding under that same purchase order.

03 • Assistant: Then I don't need to place a second order for four simply to keep the request active?

04 • Supplier: Correct. A duplicate order could create another purchase. These four are still due on P58.

05 • Assistant: Do you have a confirmed delivery date, or only an estimate at this stage?

06 • Supplier: Only an estimate of next Thursday. We'll confirm once the shipment is actually arranged.

07 • Assistant: Please label that as estimated in the update. Our team is deciding whether to use existing folders.

08 • Supplier: I can do that. Would you also like notice if the estimate changes before dispatch?

09 • Assistant: Please notify purchasing if the estimate changes, and copy our office inbox.

10 • Supplier: Agreed. Four remain on backorder, with Thursday as an estimate. I'll contact purchasing.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Querying office supplies and delivery differences

Purchase order P44 is for twelve archive boxes. The delivery note lists twelve, but the checked shipment contains ten. No second package or backorder is documented. Ask the supplier to confirm the outstanding two and whether another shipment is planned; do not approve payment or claim theft.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Supplier: order P44 shows twelve; can investigate the missing two and provide an update at three, but have no confirmed explanation yet.

Second round: The delivery note is signed. Keep the reported physical count separate from assumptions about what the signature proves.

Scenario 2 | The right quantity but the wrong size

Order S31 specifies six A4 storage trays. Six letter-size trays arrived. Ordered A4 trays: TR-A4; delivered letter-size trays: TR-LTR. The supplier can review an exchange but no collection date is confirmed.

Role A: Assistant: distinguish size mismatch from quantity shortage.

Role B: Supplier: ask for the item codes and offer a review update tomorrow morning.

Possible opening: We received six trays, but their size differs from S31.

Success checks

- Give the correct quantities and sizes.
- Keep exchange review separate from confirmed replacement.
- Avoid presenting a duplicate order as already required.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to reorder six before the supplier responds.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Two colleagues named Jordan

An assistant identifies a visitor's host.

01 • Assistant: Welcome. You mentioned Jordan; could I check the appointment reference in your invitation first?

02 • Visitor: It's V12, for ten o'clock. I don't remember whether Jordan works in facilities or sales.

03 • Assistant: V12 lists Jordan Chen in facilities. We also have a Jordan Patel, so I'm glad we checked.

04 • Visitor: Yes, the wrong Jordan wouldn't know why I brought these building plans with me.

05 • Assistant: I'll contact Jordan Chen now. Please wait here in reception while we arrange for you to be met.

06 • Visitor: Should I complete the visitor log now, or wait until Jordan confirms the meeting?

07 • Assistant: Please sign the visitor log here while I contact your host about the room.

08 • Visitor: There's Jordan on the phone. Can you ask whether the meeting is still in room four?

09 • Assistant: Jordan confirms room four and will collect you from reception in a moment.

10 • Visitor: Thank you. I'll wait by these chairs with my plans until Jordan arrives.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

The visitor arrived at the old address

An assistant helps a caller at a former office location.

01 • Assistant: You said the reception desk is closed. Which street address appears on the invitation you're using?

02 • Visitor: Eighteen Harbor Street. I printed that invitation last month and came to the same entrance.

03 • Assistant: Our current meeting invitation gives twenty-four Harbor Street. Did the update reach your email?

04 • Visitor: I see the update now. I checked the time but missed the changed address.

05 • Assistant: I'm sorry the address change wasn't clearer. I'll tell your host you're coming from number eighteen.

06 • Visitor: I'm nearby but will be about ten minutes late. Could you tell the host before I walk over?

07 • Assistant: Yes. The host confirms that arrival is workable and will wait at the current reception.

08 • Visitor: Does the appointment reference remain V38, or did it change along with the address?

09 • Assistant: It remains V38. Use twenty-four Harbor Street and the main reception entrance shown in the update.

10 • Visitor: Twenty-four Harbor Street, V38. I'll be there in ten minutes.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A companion was not on the visitor list

An assistant checks an additional visitor with the host.

01 • Assistant: The appointment lists one guest under V46, but two of you have arrived this morning.

02 • Visitor: My colleague came with me to discuss the samples. I forgot to mention them to the host.

03 • Assistant: I'll check with the host before arranging your colleague's access beyond reception.

04 • Visitor: Can we both wait in reception while you check with the host?

05 • Assistant: Certainly. May I tell the host your colleague's name and that they're joining the sample discussion?

06 • Visitor: Yes, it's Robin Ellis. There are no changes to the samples or the meeting purpose.

07 • Assistant: The host has confirmed Robin can join. We'll complete the separate visitor details for each of you.

08 • Visitor: Thank you. Should Robin use my badge, or will there be a separate one issued?

09 • Assistant: Robin needs a separate visitor badge after checking in; please keep your own.

10 • Visitor: Understood. We'll complete our own details and wait here for the host to collect us.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Welcoming visitors and checking arrangements

Visitor Taylor arrives for a 10:00 meeting with Jordan. The office has two Jordans: Jordan Chen in facilities and Jordan Patel in sales. Reference V12 names Jordan Chen. Check the reference, contact the host, and explain the reception wait; the visitor is not cleared to enter other areas alone.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Visitor: Taylor, booking V12, meeting Jordan at ten; do not know Jordan's surname.

Second round: The visitor sees someone wearing a badge and asks to follow them upstairs. Keep the host-confirmation arrangement clear.

Scenario 2 | A visitor cannot stay for the delayed meeting

A 2:00 visitor can stay only until 2:30. The host is delayed until 2:20 and needs twenty minutes. The host can instead offer a video meeting tomorrow at nine.

Role A: Assistant: relay the timing conflict and the host's alternative.

Role B: Visitor: cannot stay past 2:30 but can attend tomorrow's video call.

Possible opening: If the meeting starts at twenty past, can we still finish by half past?

Success checks

- Calculate the ten-minute remaining window accurately.
- Avoid shortening the host's meeting by assumption.
- Confirm acceptance of tomorrow's alternative and requested invitation.

Add a complication: The visitor asks you to promise the host will cut the meeting in half.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A cheaper fare with less flexibility

An assistant compares two rail quotes with a traveler.

01 • Assistant: For this journey, it's seventy nonrefundable, or a ninety-dollar refundable fare with conditions.

02 • Traveler: My meeting might move. What does conditional mean for the ninety-dollar fare you've found?

03 • Assistant: The supplied terms allow a refund before departure with a ten-dollar deduction, not a full refund.

04 • Traveler: That could matter. Does the seventy-dollar fare have the same cancellation option at a lower price?

05 • Assistant: No, that quote is nonrefundable. I haven't booked either, and purchasing approval is still needed.

06 • Traveler: Please send both options to the approver with those conditions, not just the headline prices.

07 • Assistant: I will. Is the arrival station the same one listed on your meeting invitation?

08 • Traveler: Yes, Central Station. I can reach the venue from there, but the meeting date remains unconfirmed.

09 • Assistant: I'll hold the booking until both the meeting date and purchasing approval are confirmed.

10 • Traveler: Thanks. Please contact me when the date and approval are settled, before buying anything.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A hotel date changed but the train did not

An assistant checks a colleague's itinerary.

01 • Assistant: Your hotel starts Wednesday, but the itinerary still shows Tuesday's outbound train.

02 • Traveler: The meeting moved a day. I changed the hotel, then forgot to ask about the train.

03 • Assistant: Let's check the existing train booking reference and its conditions before discussing a change.

04 • Traveler: The reference is T82. Please don't buy another ticket automatically while the original is still active.

05 • Assistant: I won't. I'll ask the travel desk what changes are available under that booking.

06 • Traveler: Could you keep the return date unchanged? The final session still ends on Friday afternoon.

07 • Assistant: Yes. The request concerns the outbound date only, with Friday's return remaining as currently booked.

08 • Traveler: The desk can review that today. Can you send me the revised itinerary only after confirmation?

09 • Assistant: I'll mark Wednesday's outbound journey pending until the travel desk confirms the change.

10 • Traveler: Good. I'll use the current reference for the query and wait before assuming the journey has moved.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A card statement is not the requested receipt

An assistant explains missing support for an expense claim.

01 • Assistant: Your expense claim includes the card statement, but the travel policy asks for the itemized hotel receipt.

02 • Traveler: I have a payment confirmation too. Does that show enough detail for this claim?

03 • Assistant: It shows payment, but not the room nights and separate items requested in this policy.

04 • Traveler: Then I need the hotel's itemized receipt. Can I ask them using my booking reference H39?

05 • Assistant: Yes. Quote H39 and the stay dates so they can locate the relevant document.

06 • Traveler: Please don't submit the claim as complete while I'm waiting for that missing receipt.

07 • Assistant: I'll keep it marked incomplete and note which document remains outstanding for the reviewer.

08 • Traveler: Could you check whether the train receipt is already included, so I don't request it again?

09 • Assistant: It is attached and readable. The hotel receipt is the only missing item identified here.

10 • Traveler: I'll ask the hotel for the receipt now and bring it back for checking.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Clarifying travel options and booking status

Two fictional rail quotes cover the same trip. A costs \$70 and is nonrefundable; B costs \$90 and permits a refund before departure with a \$10 deduction. The traveler's meeting is not confirmed. Purchasing approval is still required. Compare the supplied conditions without recommending financial or legal action.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Traveler: meeting might move; need a clear comparison and approval before any booking.

Second round: The traveler says refundable means no conditions. Read back the specific deduction and before-departure limit.

Scenario 2 | A conference venue has two nearby stations

The invitation names Riverside East station; an old itinerary names Riverside Central. Both are real destinations within this fictional exercise, and no ticket has been bought. The traveler needs the invitation's station.

Role A: Assistant: identify the destination mismatch before requesting a quote.

Role B: Traveler: confirm Riverside East and the conference date.

Possible opening: The station names are almost the same; does it matter which one is quoted?

Success checks

- Confirm Riverside East by name.
- Compare quotes for the same actual journey.
- Keep price separate from destination correctness.

Add a complication: A colleague says the cheaper quote must be correct.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Three deadlines cannot all stay the same

An assistant negotiates competing tasks with a manager.

01 • Assistant: Both original tasks take thirty minutes: visitor list by ten-thirty, room pack by eleven.

02 • Manager: Please do a twenty-minute spreadsheet check first, by ten-twenty. Can the other tasks still fit?

03 • Assistant: Not without delaying an existing deadline. No colleague is free; which commitment can we move?

04 • Manager: The visitor list must stay at ten-thirty. Could the room pack be finished a little later instead?

05 • Assistant: The training starts at eleven, so the trainer would need to agree to that delay.

06 • Manager: Keep both original deadlines. I'll accept the spreadsheet check at eleven-twenty, after the pack.

07 • Assistant: That gives each task the stated time. I'll tell you if a missing input changes the schedule.

08 • Manager: Please do. The spreadsheet can wait, but the visitor list must reach reception on time.

09 • Assistant: Visitor list first, room pack second, and your spreadsheet check by eleven-twenty.

10 • Manager: Agreed. I'll tell the person waiting for the check that I've accepted the revised time.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Coverage includes the phone, not every pending task

An assistant arranges lunch coverage.

01 • Assistant: Could you cover the reception phone from twelve to twelve-thirty while I take lunch?

02 • Colleague: Yes. Am I also taking over the supplier follow-up due at one, or only the phone?

03 • Assistant: Only the phone. I'll return before the one o'clock follow-up and keep responsibility for it.

04 • Colleague: Then please show me where the call-routing list is and which colleague handles urgent delivery questions.

05 • Assistant: The list is beside the phone. Facilities extension 214 handles delivery arrangements during that period.

06 • Colleague: I'll take messages and use that route if a delivery caller needs the team.

07 • Assistant: Thank you. There's a visitor expected at twelve-fifteen; their host knows to meet them here.

08 • Colleague: I can greet them and contact the host, but I won't change their room booking independently.

09 • Assistant: That's enough coverage. I'll be back at twelve-thirty and check any messages with you.

10 • Colleague: Fine. I'll keep the messages in the normal record and give you a short handover.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 • CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The missing list is holding up the room pack

An assistant gives a status update to a trainer.

01 • Assistant: The room pack is ready except for the final attendee list, which hasn't reached us yet.

02 • Trainer: I sent a draft yesterday with fourteen names. Can't you use that as the final list?

03 • Assistant: Yesterday's draft left two places unconfirmed. Has their attendance changed since then?

04 • Trainer: Those two have now accepted. I'll send the confirmed list of sixteen this morning.

05 • Assistant: Thank you. What time can you send it so I can prepare the correct number of packs?

06 • Trainer: By ten-fifteen. The session starts at eleven, and I need the packs delivered by ten-forty-five.

07 • Assistant: That works if the confirmed list arrives then. I'll prepare the unchanged materials while I wait.

08 • Trainer: Please avoid printing names from the draft if any corrections appear on the final version.

09 • Assistant: I will. The final list is the dependency; the other material can be prepared now.

10 • Trainer: I'll send the confirmed sixteen names by ten-fifteen and highlight the changed entries.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 • SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Prioritizing work and handing over coverage

At 10:00 an assistant has a visitor list due at 10:30 and a room pack due at 11:00. Each needs thirty minutes. A manager requests a new twenty-minute spreadsheet check by 10:20. No colleague is free. Ask the manager to choose priorities or adjust a deadline; do not promise all three.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: Manager: visitor list must stay at 10:30; can move the spreadsheet check to 11:20 while keeping the pack at eleven.

Second round: The manager calls the extra task urgent without changing its duration. Ask which existing commitment should change.

Scenario 2 | A handover recipient is unavailable

The usual afternoon cover is absent. A callback to supplier D55 is due at four. The supervisor can assign Jamie, who is available from three. No reassignment has been confirmed.

Role A: Assistant: ask the supervisor to confirm a named replacement.

Role B: Supervisor: can assign Jamie and request explicit acceptance.

Possible opening: Who will take the four o'clock supplier callback now that our usual cover is absent?

Success checks

- Name D55 and the callback time.
- Ask for a specific owner rather than a broad group.
- Confirm Jamie's acceptance before treating coverage as settled.

Add a complication: A note saying 'afternoon team' is treated as enough.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All organizations, appointments, documents, prices, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This is not legal, financial, immigration, security, or records-retention advice. Follow the employer's actual purchasing, access, privacy, travel, and approval arrangements. Sample policies and delegated responsibilities apply only to the stated exercise.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook: Secretaries and Administrative Assistants

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/office-and-administrative-support/secretaries-and-administrative-assistants.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Secretaries and Administrative Assistants, Except Legal, Medical, and Executive

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/43-6014.00>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Guided message practice gives four choices with explained feedback. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Rehearse with an AI colleague

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Office and Administrative Assistant English

Professional audience: Office assistants, administrative assistants, reception administrators, and team support staff

Scope: All organizations, appointments, documents, prices, policies, and incidents are fictional English practice. This is not legal, financial, immigration, security, or records-retention advice. Follow the employer's actual purchasing, access, privacy, travel, and approval arrangements. Sample policies and delegated responsibilities apply only to the stated exercise.

Dialogue 01: A daylight-saving assumption needs a date check

Original fictional setting: An assistant and colleague review a cross-office invitation using a supplied date-specific conversion.

Professional roles: Assistant / Colleague

Published dialogue (reference script, not my own performance):

Assistant: The draft uses last month's time difference. Our verified conversion for this meeting date is different.

Colleague: I copied the old invitation. What local times should appear for the new date?

Assistant: The calendar shows nine here and three there, not the four shown in the draft.

Colleague: Then the other office may have reserved the wrong hour. Please check before confirming the meeting.

Assistant: I'll contact their administrator with the date and both proposed local times. Our nine remains a hold.

Colleague: Could you ask whether their room is available at three too, rather than check only the person's calendar?

Assistant: I've asked. The participant can attend at three, but their room is occupied until three-thirty.

Colleague: We can meet by video without that room. Does the participant have another suitable place available?

Assistant: They confirm a smaller room at three. I'll update the invitation with the corrected local times.

Colleague: Please state that the earlier four o'clock reference was an error, so nobody relies on it.

Assistant: Done. Both participants have accepted the corrected invitation, and the old time is identified in the correction.

Colleague: Thanks. I'll use this meeting's date-specific times rather than carry the old difference into future bookings.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Interactive workplace role-play

1. Use the supplied case or dialogue as the starting situation. Give a two-sentence briefing and offer two relevant professional roles for me to choose from. For a supplied dialogue, use its actual roles. Ask which role I want, then stop and wait. Do not write my replies.
 2. After I choose, identify who you will play and the immediate communication goal. Play the other professional; where a meeting requires a third person, label each of your speakers clearly. Start with one natural workplace turn and wait for my reply. Keep most turns to one to three sentences and ask no more than one question at a time.
 3. Let the exchange develop across six to ten learner turns, or end earlier if I type "feedback". Respond to what I actually say. Include a plausible clarification, disagreement or tradeoff without silently changing the starting facts. Mark any added constraint as a fictional second-round variation. Do not resolve approvals, evidence or commitments that remain uncertain.
 4. Stay in role during the exchange. If my meaning is unclear, ask for clarification naturally. Give a hint only if I ask or cannot proceed. Do not deliver a model conversation in advance.
 5. At the debrief, quote two of my phrases: one successful choice and one worth improving. Check factual accuracy, language, register and whether the next step was clear. Give up to three focused suggestions. Ask me to retry the weakest turn; wait. Only then offer an alternative wording and a harder replay.
- Use voice replies when available. If I prefer selections, offer four plausible spoken replies and explain my choice before continuing. Do not require written compositions.

END PROMPT

Create more scenario dialogues

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT | ONLINE VERSION

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When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

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Assistant: Done. Both participants have accepted the corrected invitation, and the old time is identified in the correction.

Colleague: Thanks. I'll use this meeting's date-specific times rather than carry the old difference into future bookings.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Extend the conversation library

1. Propose six distinct, common scenarios in this field beyond the supplied case or script. For each, name the setting, two or more professional roles, the communication problem and one useful terminology focus. Include routine coordination, clarification, a complication, disagreement, handoff and follow-up where relevant. Choose scenarios that fit this profession, rather than forcing unsuitable situations into it.
2. Ask me to choose one scenario, or request all six in sequence. Stop and wait. Do not write all the scripts before I choose.
3. For the selected scenario, write an original fictional dialogue of 12-18 substantial speaking turns between two or three professionals. Name each role, establish an actual work problem, and let the exchange progress through questions, clarification, competing constraints and a credible next step or explicitly unresolved issue. Use the occupation's natural nomenclature and register. Avoid an interview between a teacher and a learner, generic small talk, and inserting a glossary definition into every reply. Explain specialist terms outside the dialogue instead.
4. After the script, explain five useful expressions in context, identify two grammar or register choices and ask three questions about the speakers' reasoning. Withhold the answers until I attempt them. Add one role-switch challenge.
5. Before presenting a script, check names, numbers, chronology, roles and terminology for consistency. Label invented facts and acknowledge uncertain specialist usage. If I requested all six, deliver one complete script at a time and wait for "next". Make each scenario materially different.

END PROMPT